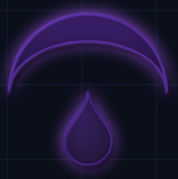
CORE:HACK

BLACKOUT

PLAYER'S MANUAL

Planet Earth, 2091.
The Net belongs to whoever can afford it.



Core:Hack: Blackout 2.10.2 - Guido Cauli <guido.cauli@gmail.com>

01

The world

Thirty years after the Great Blackout that killed the old Internet, the Net is private property. Cables, nodes and data belong to the Corporate Concord, which rents access to citizens by the metre.

NetGuard polices it in the name of order. The Lumen Collective wants it free and public. The Black Net lives at its edges and does business there. In between are people like you: an old gateway, a terminal and no master.

> *Every contract is a choice. Getting in is easy. Deciding which side you are on, when nobody is watching, is the hard part.*



The title screen: choose a codename and begin.

As an independent operator you take on intrusion contracts (**red team**) and defence contracts (**blue team**), upgrade your gateway, buy ever more powerful programs and build a reputation with the four factions fighting over the Net. Every job has a price, in credits (¢) and in conscience.

There is no right path: you can be a respected professional, a mercenary, an idealist or a criminal. The factions remember what you do, and the Net forgets little.

02

The four factions

Four powers carve up the Net between them. Your **reputation** with each one (from -100 to +100) is shown in the Profile and decides which contracts you are offered, which gateways open up and what your name is worth. Each has a public face and one it would rather not show: whoever offers you a contract tells you only what it takes to

convince you.

Serving one almost always means betraying another.



NETGUARD

"Order, above all."

You never see them coming: one morning your gateway answers half a second slower than usual, and you realise that somewhere someone has opened a file with your name on it. NetGuard, the Net's police, never knocks on the door but takes note of everything, and keeps a record on every cable, every node and every operator, even those who have never broken a rule: it calls them "precautions". To those who cooperate it is a patient ally, offering official contracts, paying on time and able to turn a raid into a simple warning; to everyone else it is an eye that never closes.

What they don't tell you: who watches the watchmen? Somewhere inside NetGuard an order that was never written down is going round, telling people to look the other way, but only at certain moments and for certain clients, and in the official records you will not find the signature of whoever gave it.

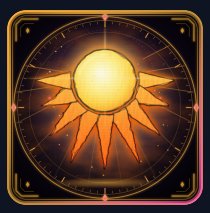


CORPORATE CONCORD

"The market regulates itself."

The Concord has no need to threaten anyone, because it owns the cables, the nodes and the data the Net runs on, and it only has to put a contract on the table to get what it wants. It is the consortium of the megacorporations, the richest and most frequent client you will find, and it commissions penetration tests, audits and industrial espionage with the same icy courtesy, paying well for the work and better for the silence, as long as nobody asks how it was done.

What they don't tell you: the Net is something you rent, and someone in the boardrooms has already decided how much it costs to keep it alive: sooner or later you had better ask yourself what you are really protecting, and from whom.

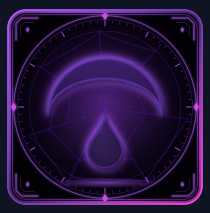


LUMEN COLLECTIVE

"The Net belongs to everyone."

Lumen has no money and few resources, but it has one thing the corporations cannot buy: the conviction of being on the right side. They are hacktivists, journalists, former employees and kids with an idea, and they ask you for leaks, debts to erase and data to set free in exchange for modest fees and sincere gratitude, the kind that welcomes beginners and knows how to make those who abandon them feel guilty.

What they don't tell you: a free Net has a price, and it is not always paid by those who chose it: the people of Lumen have debts, fears and weak spots, and someone outside the collective has already noticed.



THE BLACK NET

"No questions asked here."

It has no address and appears on no map: the first message always comes from someone who already knows too much about you, how much you owe, whom you have let down and what you would be willing to do to settle the bill. It is the underground market of blackmail, sabotage and theft to order, where the pay is the highest on the Net and the consequences the worst, and where a promise is kept with a punctuality that should frighten you more than a threat.

What they don't tell you: they know the value of every piece of information and have a very precise idea of what yours is worth: they will treat you with respect as long as you are useful, and after that it depends.

In the shadows

Beneath the everyday contracts something else flows. It has no name, and those who know it have stopped saying it aloud. Someone has been pulling the strings since long before the Blackout. Now and then the Net lets a fragment slip: a contract that should not exist, a name no archive remembers. If you let the right person find you, perhaps you will be offered a look. Not everything should be read, and not everything should be read by you.

03

Your conscience

Moral choices are measured on two axes: **Legality** (are you inside or outside the law?) and **Ethics** (are you on the side of the exposed, or of those who exploit them?). The two axes can pull in opposite directions. Your position on the **moral plane** (Profile window) gives you your label:

Hat	Who you are
White Hat	You work within the law and for those who are exposed. People trust you, but the pay is modest.
Grey Hat	You break the rules when you need to, or keep quiet when it suits you. No label fits you tightly.
Black Hat	You break the law and whoever gets caught in between. It pays well, while it lasts.
Mercenary	The law is on your side, your conscience perhaps not. You carry out orders others would not sign.

Heat and the police

Heat (from 0 to 100, in the Profile) measures how closely NetGuard is watching you. Every unauthorised operation and every trace left on the nodes makes it rise; as the days go by it slowly falls. When it is high NetGuard may **raid** you: a fine, the seizure of a program or a component, even arrest. Wiping the logs before you leave reduces the traces left behind, and so the heat you build up.

Money

The gateway costs money: every week you pay for the connection and the rent. If your debts pass a threshold the gateway is repossessed and the game is over. Choose your contracts with an eye on how much risk you can afford.

The Profile

The **Profile** window (opened from the hat in the top bar, mouse only) shows your moral plane, NetGuard heat and your reputation with the four factions.



The Profile: moral plane, heat and reputation.

04

Contracts

Jobs appear in the **Gateway window** (F1 key, Contracts tab). Every contract has a client, a deadline, a difficulty and a **class** describing how legal it is, shown by a colour:

Class	Meaning
Official (blue)	Legal work, openly negotiated.
Sanctioned (green)	Authorised, but with ambiguous implications.
Irregular (orange)	Unauthorised, but harmless.
Dangerous (red)	Unauthorised and harmful.

Red team and blue team

Red team contracts are intrusions: you get into a network, get past its protections and bring out what the client asks for. **Blue team** contracts are defences: you read the security logs, spot the attackers and stop them before they do damage. Both share the same board; the first contract is a safe exercise that teaches you the basics.

The hardest contracts require a **minimum reputation** with the client: those out of reach stay on the board marked REP, but cannot be accepted until you earn their trust.

Special terms

Before accepting a contract you can press **Terms...** and take it with a variant (one per contract; never in story missions, defence contracts or NetGuard jobs, since NetGuard does not negotiate). If you fail (traced, terms broken, contract abandoned or expired) the extra reputation loss adds to the usual one.

Variant	You get	You risk
Premium rate	+10–20% pay	one more condition from the client (a trace ceiling of 65–75%, a time limit, or all optional leads made mandatory); if you fail, −6 reputation
Half advance	half the pay at once, the rest when the mission succeeds	−10 reputation and the advance to pay back
Full advance	all the pay at once; on success only the bonuses remain	−20 reputation and the advance to pay back

Advances require reputation with the client (20 and 50; 10 and 35 with the Black Net). If you cannot pay the advance back you have **3 days** to settle it (it is settled automatically as soon as you have the money; meanwhile you cannot take another one). Then the faction gets even in its own way: the Concord seizes programs and hardware, the Black Net steals items from your archive, Lumen exposes your identity; always with more attention and a worse record, and after a full advance everything doubles and it can end in arrest.

Clues

Irregular contracts and above hide **extra files** in the network (shown in cyan in the list and marked *[clue]* in *ls*) and **things to do** during the intrusion: wiping the logs of a host, leaving a RevShell, finishing without raising the alarm. They are not needed to succeed, but when the contract succeeds each one pays an extra fee and a little reputation; the things to do also give an archive fragment. Hints about the things to do are found in the clue files.

Marked files

Some encrypted files carry a **network tracer**: the harder the network, the more likely it is and the stronger the tracer (levels 1-5). A secret file can carry one too. By sight they cannot be told apart from other files: only **Inspect** recognises them, marking them in violet. If you download them you accept the risk: after a certain number of game hours the tracer fires (you see it in the archive) and a **Siege** becomes more likely. Winning the siege removes the tracers and leaves you the files; losing it costs you the traced files. The owner's enemy faction may ask you for the file with a delivery contract (you upload the file to one of its hosts): it pays well, but costs reputation with the owner and, from level 3, it is a betrayal and draws retaliation. Alternatively the Broker may step forward, paying more and raising the Black Net's regard for you (not for thefts from the Black Net).

XMapper: secret links and hosts

From grade-8 contracts upward a network may hide **secret links** (shortcuts between distant hosts, never across VLANs) and **secret hosts**: ordinary hosts, with the same defences, but hidden and holding **loot files** in orange (downloading them pays extra when the contract succeeds). Without **XMapper** you cannot see them. XMapper is a NetSonar add-on: a single level, expensive, sold only at faction gateways, it requires NetSonar v4 and Inspect v2. Once installed there is no extra button: the normal scan of a host reveals its secret links (violet dashed lines on the map) and the hidden hosts they lead to. **Argus**, the Primary NetSonar, already includes XMapper.

Archives

Nothing truly disappears from a network: sooner or later it ends up in an archive. From grade 6, **backup hosts** appear at the bottom of networks: **NAS** units, and from grade 10 **SANs** (a few huge volumes) and **tape libraries** (many cartridge sets). They rely on isolation more than armour, but their files are large. Sometimes an archive keeps a **copy** of the file you are deleting or altering: leave it, and the file comes back from the backup and the client pays less.

Some contracts revolve around archives: **delete everywhere** (the job is only done when no copy is left), **find the copy** (the archive does not show on the map until you download the backup job log from the host the file vanished from), **destroy the archive** (empty it first, then take it down: a host that is down can no longer be emptied) and, in defence, **protect it** from a ransomware crew, even by setting it to **write-once** for a while (`worm`): nobody can encrypt it, but backups stop.

Lieutenants

Factions do not send their leaders right away. At first jobs come from **desks, offices, committees and bulletin boards**; as your reputation grows (around 25, 32 and 40 points) the **lieutenants** show up, three per faction, each with their own way of working: which contracts they offer, how much they pay, what deadlines and conditions they set. Now and then a contract on the board bears their signature, and they remember how it went: trust is shown in the Directory, under **Lieutenants**.

Some are **rivals** within the same faction: doing well for one irritates the other. If trust leans clearly to one side, that one keeps an eye on you (more jobs, better paid) and the other cools off, until they stop dealing with you. With enough trust each one also offers two **personal contracts**, with a follow-up

written by them. Under their letters there are buttons to reply: saying no cools them, but never blocks the story. **From 50 points** of reputation the lieutenant you trust most introduces you to the leader, and the faction stories begin.

Honeypots, conflicting leads and automatic admins

From grade-7 contracts some hosts are **honeypots**: ordinary-looking hosts (often with a clue file as bait) that spring a trap when you break their first barrier: a burst of trace, one more alert level (two from grade 14) and a few seconds of sharper surveillance. They never fail the contract, are never on the cheapest path and are never mandatory. A scan makes them **suspected** (amber jar with a "?"); with **Inspect** at the trap's level and a good enough NetSonar they are **confirmed** (red jar with an "x").

From grade 9 some contracts add **conflicting optional leads** (the base contract can always be done): in a **pair** two leads exclude each other (after the first, the admin moves the other), a **tripwire** lead sets off an alarm when you read it and clashes with the "quiet" lead. Inspect marks tripwires in violet.

From grade 11 **automatic admins** (one per network of a VLAN chain) act on hosts you have already opened, always with a warning in the Log and on the map (orange icon with a countdown): **audit** (if traces remain, the alarm goes up), **password change**, **services restart** and, from grade 16, **session close**. They never touch a target host while you are working on it and they stop once the objective is reached. The CLI `status` line also shows your **player level** (from 1.00 to 20.00, comparable with contract grades).



The Gateway window, Contracts tab: class, difficulty, client and pay. Below, the details and the "Accept contract" button.

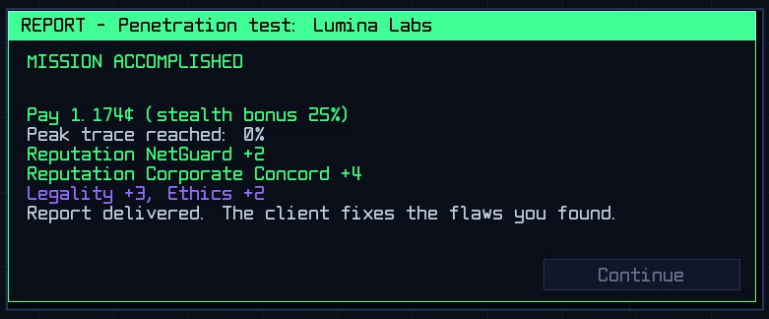
05

How a game works

1	**Hub** Between missions you pick a contract, buy components and programs and let time pass.
2	**Accept and connect** Accept a contract and press **Connect** in its details; first choose how many relays to use.

3	**Mission** Intrusion or defence, in real time. Market and Profile stay locked while you are connected.
4	**Report** Pay, reputation, heat and moral consequences. You return to the hub and the game saves by itself.

Game time runs in days: contracts expire, bills arrive, hardware upgrades take hours. During a mission the clock runs in real time (30 game seconds for every real second) and you can adjust the speed or pause.



The end-of-mission report: pay, reputation and moral consequences.

At the end of every contract the game saves automatically. You can also save and load by hand from the save window (F9, or from the Options).

06

Basic controls

Everything is done with the **mouse**: click buttons, click a node to select it, use the wheel to scroll long lists, drag windows by their title bar (close them with the **x** at the top right; a **double click** on the bar rolls them up and unrolls them again). When you hover over an element, the text at the bottom shows a hint.

Key	Action
F1 – F8	Open and close the windows.
F9	Save slots (save and load).
F10	Music on/off.
F11	Fullscreen (the choice is remembered).
Esc	Opens the Options, or closes modal windows.
Space	Pause (in a mission). You cannot act while paused.
1 / 2 / 3	Normal / double / quadruple speed (in a mission).

In a mission, with the Network window in front, some letters act on the **selected node** just like the buttons: **s** scan, **b** the outermost barrier, **f** / **p** / **c** / **e** the Firewall / Proxy / Password / Elliptic curve barrier, **m** blinds the monitor, **d** downloads a file, **l** wipes the logs, **r** RevShell. **Tab** moves to the next known node, **Del** cancels the last operation started on the node. The full list is in the Advanced Manual; each button's key also appears in its hint.

The Options

From the **CORE:HACK** logo at the top left (or with Esc) you set music and effects, volume, brightness, the **HUD hue** (it changes the base colour of the system without touching the contrasts), the screen effect, the **animations** (Full, Reduced or Off), the **trace difficulty** (from Easy to Very hard) and fullscreen; from here you save, return to the main menu or quit. Your choices are remembered. The language is chosen on the title screen, before you start, and cannot be changed during the game.

Theme: the **Change theme...** button (on the fullscreen row) opens a list with Core, Introvert, Ami and Tensor. A click previews it at once on the whole interface; **Confirm** keeps it and remembers it, **Cancel** (or Esc) goes back. The neon themes also switch on the Modern style; Ami uses its own pixel font. Ami uses the Classic style, flat windows with a white border and no shadows, and a boot sequence of its own: black, shades of grey, a blue background and a window with the text. In every theme a pressed button shows it: in the bevelled themes the light and shadow of the edges are swapped.



The Options.

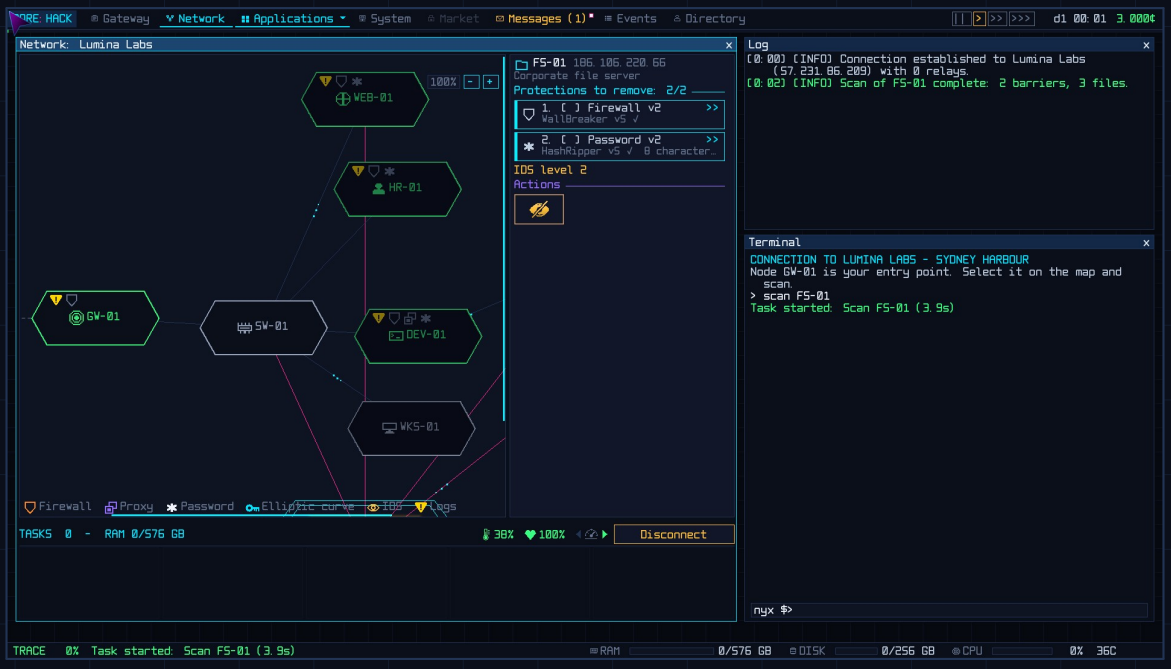
The terminal

The terminal (Applications menu, F3 or Ctrl+T) accepts the same actions as the buttons. The `help` command lists those available in the context you are in: hub, intrusion or defence.

07

The intrusion

A red team contract gives you access to a network of nodes: file servers, mail, databases, workstations, vaults. Each node is defended by one or more **protections** and can only be reached from an adjacent node you have already opened. Harder networks are larger and have more alternative routes; **Switches** are hubs without files that link several hosts (lighter defences) and, in VLAN missions, are the only portal to the network below.



An intrusion: the node map on the left, tasks and log below, the terminal on the right.

The method

1. Scan the node (NetSonar): its protections, its files and the program needed against each one appear.
2. Disable or break the protections: firewalls and proxies are *disabled*, passwords and elliptic curves are *broken*. One after another, or in parallel on different slots.
3. Take what you need: decrypt (**D**), download (**G**), delete (**X**) or alter (**E**) the files.
4. Leave clean: wipe the logs (*Wipe logs*) and disconnect.

Every protection is brought down by a program of **at least the same level**. If you do not own the right program, its button does not appear.

Keeping the trace low

Move	Why
Relay	Intermediate hosts that slow the trace down, but add latency. The better they are, the better.
Blind	Blinds the surveillance monitors (IDS) for a while before you attack watched nodes.
Wipe	Erases the traces left on a node, once the objective is done.
Patience	More programs in parallel means less speed for each: don't launch everything at once.

Every action makes noise and the trace rises; it never cools down by itself. At **100%** you are traced: the mission fails and you pay the consequences. An interrupted intrusion leaves the alarm raised even if you come back later.

Defence (blue team)

In defence contracts you read the security logs, pick a suspicious address and **block** it (attackers change address after a while), isolate or recover nodes, watch some of them (3 with the basic network card, then one more every 2 NIC levels) and, against malware and ransomware, clean and shield the systems. Attackers switch between hosts: now and then they probe other hosts (from 1 per round at grade 1 to 10 at grade 20, up to 5 at a time) while the real path slows down and goes quiet; identical logs close together on the same host merge into one line with a counter (x3). Instead of the trace there is the company's **uptime**: keep it high. A passive defender always loses.



Defence: the network to protect, the company's status and the console with the security logs.

08

Gateway, hardware and programs

The gateway is your base: what you own and what you can afford. In the **System** window (F4) its tabs show **Hardware**, **Programs** (only those you own), **Microcode**, **Relays** and **Storage**; career statistics are in the Profile; in the **Market** (F5) you upgrade them.

Hardware

Component	Effect
Processor	How fast programs run.
Memory	How many programs run in parallel (slots).
Network Card (NIC)	Transfer speed of files and programs.
Storage	Space for downloaded data. Files stay on disk after the mission: delete them by hand (Delete button in the Storage tab, or `drop n`).
Cloak	How many relays you can chain and how much the trace slows down.

An upgrade takes **8 game hours** and a **reboot** of the gateway to take effect: the shutdown and restart sequence is part of the charm.

Programs

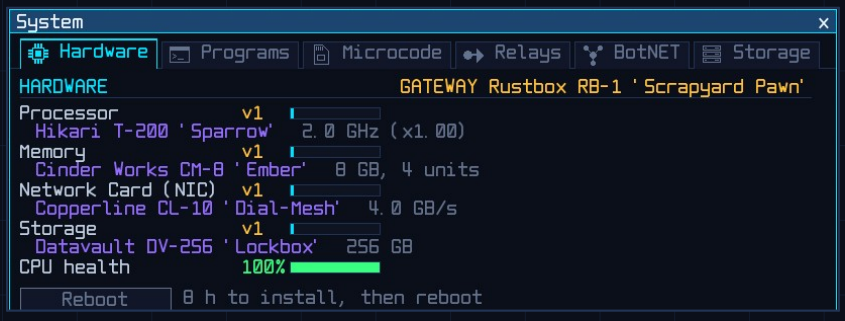
You start with NetSonar, WallBreaker, ProxyMask and HashRipper at level 1; the others must be bought in the Market. In the Market you will find more powerful programs and new specialities: discover them as you play.

Program	What it does
NetSonar	scans nodes
WallBreaker	disables firewalls
ProxyMask	gets around proxies
HashRipper	cracks passwords
TraceHound	blue team: traces the attackers

Microcode

The processor does what its microcode tells it. Cards that rewrite it circulate in the networks: **Microcode**. Each one makes the processor work differently: quicker at breaking barriers but noisier, more discreet in transfers but slower, sturdier when the gateway is under siege. It almost always asks for something in return: common ones trade an advantage for a cost of the same weight, rare ones give more and ask less, special ones are pieces few operators have ever seen. There are 96, numbered.

They hide in networks, in files whose name starts with a dot: without Inspect you cannot see them. Operators' networks keep more of them, and online they are won in races. The processor holds only a few, up to five on top-end models, and they can only be swapped with the gateway idle, from the **Microcode** tab of System. Two Microcode that do the same thing do not add up: the processor listens to the best one. A gateway that falls under siege may lose one.



The System window: installed hardware and programs.

KeyWraith

There is a way of knowing that asks you to force nothing: let them do the typing. **KeyWraith** (requires DeepRoot v3 and GhostShell v3) is a keystroke recorder you plant on an already-open host of a company in the Directory, with `keylog <host>` or from the node panel. It stays there after the contract and now and then mails you what it gathers: what depends on the host — administration leaves important passwords, accounting the books, workstations the name and access of whoever uses them, archives the way to the target — and on how deep it sits in the network: the further in, the more it counts. Higher versions gather more often and run more recorders at once, never more than one in the same company.

In time someone notices: the **Dossier** tab shows how much it is at risk, and `keylog pull <company>` pulls it out without leaving traces. If they find it first, the company stays on guard for a few days. Planting it weighs on your conscience.

09

People

Machines tell the truth about the people who use them. Read enough files and you know who works where, who they talk to, how much they owe and what they hide. Luck doesn't count here: what counts is what you have found.

The dossier

Every company in the Directory has people you can get to know: the department they work in, the colleague or supplier they talk to, the machine they log in from, and sometimes a debt or a secret. What you download in their networks tells the story: personnel records and accounts say who does what and from where, ledgers say who is struggling, evidence and hidden files say who has something to lose. Each file adds a piece; the **Dossier** button, on the company's card, gathers it all.

The lure

A message written for one person only: it seems to come from someone they know, it talks about their job, it lands on their machine. Every true detail makes it believable. The Black Net needs just one; Lumen wants two confirmations; the Concord and NetGuard need all three. When you know enough the lure goes out, and a few hours later, on the next contract against their company, you enter from their machine. Nobody falls for it twice.

The insider

Some work for you because they need to, some because they cannot say no. With a debt uncovered you can pay them: they stay loyal as long as the money arrives, every week. With a secret you can blackmail them: it costs nothing, but it doesn't last, and if you get traced at that company they break. While it lasts, contracts against their company start with less alert, one monitor is already off and every job brings a tip about a colleague.

Customer service

Account holders also give themselves away piece by piece, in bank registers and statements: their city, their employer, a relative. Customer service asks its questions before resetting a password; with all the answers, **Account recovery** in the Bank leaves the password in your address book.

The other side

In defence the same weapon is aimed at you. During a Control, staff requests come in: an access, an exception, an alarm to switch off. Sometimes it is the attacker using an employee's name, and you recognise it by what doesn't add up: the hurry, the unusual channel, the secrecy, the request to switch off a control. **Approve** or **Block**: if you don't answer, the staff go ahead on their own. Deceiving people weighs on your conscience, and blackmail most of all.

10

Keyboard shortcuts

All the game's keyboard shortcuts, in one place.

Key	Action
F1	Gateway: contracts and ranking.
F2	Network (mission only).
F3 / Ctrl+T	Terminal (Applications menu).
F4	System: hardware and programs.
F5	Black Market (not during a mission).
F6	Messages.
F7	Events.
F8	Defence Console (mission only).
F9	Save slots (save and load).
F10	Music on/off.
F11	Fullscreen (the choice is remembered).
Esc	Opens the Options; closes modal windows, lists and dialogs; in a table cell it cancels the edit.
Space	Pause (in a mission).
1 / 2 / 3	Normal / double / quadruple speed (in a mission).
Enter	In the terminal runs the command; in a table cell accepts the edit; in messages confirms.
Tab	In the terminal completes commands, nodes and files; in a table cell accepts the edit.
Up / Down	In the terminal browse the command history; in lists move the selection.
PgUp / PgDn	In the terminal scroll the output by 10 lines.
Ctrl+L	In the terminal clears the screen.
Backspace	Deletes the last character wherever you type.

Space and 1/2/3 do nothing while the Terminal is in front or while you are typing in a table cell or a text box: there the keys are text. Locked windows (Network and Defence outside missions, Black Market during a mission) show a notice instead of opening.

11

Getting started

1. **NetSonar** reveals a node's defences and files: always scan before you act.
2. A program must be at least the same level as the defence it faces.
3. Bounce relays slow down the trace, but increase latency.
4. Once the objective is done, wipe the logs: every trace left behind draws NetGuard's attention.
5. Moral choices weigh on two axes, legality and ethics, and they can pull in opposite directions.
6. Start with the training contract: it is legal, authorised and risk-free.
7. Put money aside for the weekly bills before spending it on upgrades.

Good luck, operator.

On this Net, nobody is coming to save you.